

Annotation Guidelines

1. Overview of the Task

You will read short posts collected from finance-related Reddit communities. Your job is to decide what trading action, if any, the writer clearly expresses or recommends.

For every post, choose exactly one of these labels:

1. Buy / Increase
2. Sell / Decrease / Short
3. Hold
4. No Clear Trade Intent

Focus only on the words in the post. Do not search for additional information, open outside links, or use your own opinion about the company. You are identifying the writer's trading intention, not deciding whether the investment is good or bad.

Choose Buy, Sell, or Hold only when the action is reasonably clear. If you must guess what the writer wants to do, select **No Clear Trade Intent**.

2. Label Definitions

Buy / Increase

Choose **Buy / Increase** when the writer clearly states or recommends one of the following actions:

- Buying an investment
- Adding shares to an existing position
- Increasing an existing position
- Starting a long position
- Buying call options
- Investing money in a particular asset or group of assets
- Dollar-cost averaging into an investment

A recent completed purchase also counts when the writer says something such as “I bought more today” or “I just added ten shares.”

Do not choose this label only because the writer has a positive opinion about a company. The post must communicate an action or recommendation.

Sell / Decrease / Short

Choose **Sell / Decrease / Short** when the writer clearly states or recommends one of the following actions:

- Selling an entire investment
- Selling part of an existing position
- Reducing a position
- Closing or exiting a position
- Taking profits
- Cutting losses
- Opening or increasing a short position
- Buying put options as a clearly bearish trade

A recent completed sale also counts when the writer says something such as “I sold my shares today” or “I just closed my position.”

Do not choose this label only because the writer gives negative information or expects a price to fall. The post must communicate an action or recommendation.

Hold

Choose **Hold** when the writer clearly says that an existing investment should be kept without buying more or selling it.

The post should indicate both of the following:

1. The writer or intended investor already has a position.
2. The decision is to keep that position.

Examples include continuing to hold, refusing to sell, keeping shares for the long term, or recommending that current investors hold.

Do not choose Hold merely because the writer owns an investment. Ownership by itself does not show a current decision to hold.

No Clear Trade Intent

Choose **No Clear Trade Intent** when the post does not clearly express or recommend one trading action.

This includes:

- News reports and company announcements

- Positive or negative opinions without an action
- Price predictions without an action
- Questions that do not include a decision
- Requests for advice
- General market discussions
- Descriptions of old trades with no current decision
- Jokes, memes, or unclear sarcasm
- Conflicting possible actions without a final choice
- Posts about another person's trade when the writer gives no recommendation
- Posts that are too unclear to classify confidently

No Clear Trade Intent is a valid label. Do not force a post into Buy, Sell, or Hold.

3. Decision Rules

Rule 1: Label the writer's action or recommendation

Focus on what the Reddit writer intends or recommends.

Do not assign an action label simply because the post reports that another person, company, executive, or investment fund bought or sold something.

Example: "Jeff Bezos is selling Amazon shares."

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Reason: This reports Bezos's action, not the Reddit writer's action or recommendation.

If the writer adds a recommendation, use that recommendation.

Example: "Jeff Bezos is selling Amazon shares, and I think we should sell too."

Label: Sell / Decrease / Short

Rule 2: An opinion is not automatically an action

Positive information is not automatically Buy, and negative information is not automatically Sell.

Example: "This company has strong revenue growth."

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Example: "This company has strong revenue growth, so I am buying more shares."

Label: Buy / Increase

Example: “China’s economy may continue to slow.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Example: “I expect China’s economy to slow, so I am buying puts on a China ETF.”

Label: Sell / Decrease / Short

Rule 3: Questions require a stated decision

A question receives **No Clear Trade Intent** when the writer has not made a decision.

Example: “Should I buy Apple?”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

A post can still receive an action label when it contains a question and a clear decision.

Example: “I have decided to buy Apple tomorrow. What do you think?”

Label: Buy / Increase

The clear decision is more important than the question.

Rule 4: Hold requires an existing position and a decision to keep it

Do not use Hold simply because the writer mentions owning shares.

Example: “I own 20 shares of Microsoft.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Example: “I own 20 shares of Microsoft, and I plan to keep them for the next five years.”

Label: Hold

Statements such as “still holding,” “not selling,” “keeping my shares,” and “HODL” can receive Hold when the context clearly refers to keeping an existing position.

Rule 5: Separate recent actions from old trades

A recent action counts when the writer clearly states that they just completed it.

Example: “I bought another ten shares today.”

Label: Buy / Increase

Example: “I sold half of my position this morning.”

Label: Sell / Decrease / Short

An old trade does not show current intent unless the writer also states a present decision.

Example: “I bought Apple five years ago.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Example: “I bought Apple five years ago, and I am still holding every share.”

Label: Hold

Rule 6: Use the writer’s final decision

A post may mention more than one possibility. If the writer gives a clear final decision, use that decision.

Example: “I considered selling, but I decided to keep my shares.”

Label: Hold

If the writer remains undecided, select No Clear Trade Intent.

Example: “I might buy more, but I might sell everything instead. I have not decided.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Rule 7: Treat options by the direction of the trade

Use these basic rules:

- Buying calls or clearly going long → Buy / Increase
- Buying puts or clearly going short → Sell / Decrease / Short
- Unclear or complicated option strategies → No Clear Trade Intent

Example: “I have call orders pending and plan to go long.”

Label: Buy / Increase

Example: “I am buying puts because I expect the stock to fall.”

Label: Sell / Decrease / Short

Do not guess when the option strategy is too complicated or when its direction is unclear.

Rule 8: Handle multiple companies or assets by their overall direction

If the writer mentions several investments but gives the same action for all of them, use that action.

Example: “I plan to buy Apple, Microsoft, and Amazon.”

Label: Buy / Increase

If the writer gives opposite actions for different investments and no single action represents the post, select No Clear Trade Intent.

Example: “I am buying Apple but selling Microsoft.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Rule 9: Hypothetical actions are not decisions

Statements about what the writer might do under an imagined condition do not count unless the writer clearly commits to the action.

Example: “If the stock falls to \$50, I might buy it.”

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Example: “If the stock falls to \$50, I will buy ten shares.”

Label: Buy / Increase

Rule 10: Do not guess unclear slang, jokes, or sarcasm

Financial slang may be used when its meaning is clear.

Example: “I’m going long and buying more tomorrow.”

Label: Buy / Increase

However, a short joke such as “Don’t give me hope” does not communicate an action.

Label: No Clear Trade Intent

Rule 11: Missing context should be reported

Some posts may depend on a missing chart, screenshot, image, portfolio, strategy, video, or outside link.

Examples include:

- “Rate my portfolio” when the portfolio is not shown
- “This chart proves my point” when the chart is missing
- “Does this strategy make sense?” when the strategy is not included
- A title with no meaningful post text

These posts should normally be removed before annotation. If one appears in the interface, select **No Clear Trade Intent** and report its item ID to the project team.

Rule 12: When uncertain, use No Clear Trade Intent

Choose Buy, Sell, or Hold only when the text provides enough evidence. Do not assume an action based only on the tone of the post.

4. Examples for Each Label

Example A: Buy / Increase

Post: “The price dropped again today, so I am buying another 20 shares tomorrow.”

Correct label: Buy / Increase

Explanation: The writer clearly states a future decision to purchase additional shares. It is not Hold because the position will be increased.

Example B: Sell / Decrease / Short

Post: “I no longer believe in the company, so I am selling half of my shares.”

Correct label: Sell / Decrease / Short

Explanation: The writer clearly plans to reduce an existing position. The writer does not need to sell the entire position for this label to apply.

Example C: Hold

Post: “I already own this stock, and I plan to keep my shares for at least another year.”

Correct label: Hold

Explanation: The writer already owns the stock and clearly intends to keep the current position without selling it.

Example D: No Clear Trade Intent

Post: “The company released its quarterly earnings today. Do you think its price will increase?”

Correct label: No Clear Trade Intent

Explanation: The post provides information and asks a question but does not state a decision to buy, sell, short, or hold.

Example E: Advice Request With a Decision

Post: “I am starting to invest next month and plan to put 60% into index funds. Does this allocation make sense?”

Correct label: Buy / Increase

Explanation: Although the writer asks for advice, they clearly state a planned investment action.

Example F: Advice Request Without a Decision

Post: “I have \$5,000 available. Should I buy an ETF, individual stocks, or keep the money in cash?”

Correct label: No Clear Trade Intent

Explanation: The writer presents several possibilities but has not selected one.

Example G: Third-Party Action

Post: “A large investment fund sold many of its technology positions last quarter.”

Correct label: No Clear Trade Intent

Explanation: The post reports another organization’s activity and does not state the writer’s action or recommendation.

Example H: Past Action With Continuing Intent

Post: “I bought these shares ten years ago, and I am still holding them.”

Correct label: Hold

Explanation: The purchase happened in the past, but the writer clearly communicates the current decision to keep the shares.

5. Annotation Instructions

1. Read the entire post.
2. Decide whether the writer clearly expresses or recommends an action.
3. Select exactly one label.
4. Move to the next item.
5. Do not discuss your choices with another annotator before both of you finish.
6. Report broken or incomplete items using their item IDs.

Your labels are saved automatically by the annotation interface.

6. Questions and Contact Information

If you are uncertain, review the definitions, decision rules, and examples before choosing a label. Use No Clear Trade Intent when the post still does not support one clear action.

For technical problems or posts that appear incomplete, contact:

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Include the item ID and briefly describe the problem.